But it wasn't my fault. Anxiety, by this point, was controlling my body, my life. And this speech, which I believed meant so much to so many, couldn't help but exacerbate my condition.

Plus, the producer told me as I walked onstage that we were running behind on time. *Ah, great, something else to think about. Thanks.*

As I reached the lectern, which I'd personally and carefully positioned, I berated myself, because it afforded a perfect view of all the competitors. All those trusting, wholesome, expectant faces—counting on me. I forced myself to look away, to look at nothing. Hurrying, hyper-conscious of the clock, I bleated out: *For some of those taking part this will be a stepping-stone to elite sport. But for others it will mark the end of a chapter in their recovery and the beginning of a new one.*

I went and found my seat, down front, beside Pa, who put a hand on my shoulder. *Well done, darling boy.* He was being kind. He knew I'd rushed the speech. For once I was glad not to hear the raw truth from him.

Just on the numbers, Invictus was a hit. Two million people watched on TV, thousands filled the arenas for each event. Among the highlights, for me, was the wheelchair rugby final, Britain versus America, thousands of fans cheering Britain on to victory in the Copper Box.

Wherever I went that week, people came up to me, shook my hand, told me their stories. Children, parents, grandparents, always with tears in their eyes, told me that these games had restored something they'd feared forever lost: the true spirit of a son, a daughter, a brother, a sister, a mum, a dad. One woman tapped me on the shoulder and told me I'd resurrected her husband's smile.

Oh, that smile, she said. *I hadn't seen it since he got injured.*

I knew Invictus would do some good in the world, I always *knew*, but I was caught off guard by this wave of appreciation and gratitude. And joy.

Then came the emails. Thousands, each more moving than the last.

I've had a broken back for five years, but after watching these brave men and women I've got off the sofa today and I'm ready to begin again.

I've been suffering depression since returning from Afghanistan but this demonstration of human courage and resilience has made me see…